Multimodal and Online Writing: Creative Interaction between Text and Image

18



FIGURE 18.1 Multimodal text incorporates many different types of communication, making it visually and aurally compelling as well as highly accessible for audiences. (credit: "Computer Internet Tools Gadgets Edited 2020" by www.mechanicalcaveman.com/flickr, CC BY 2.0)

CHAPTER OUTLINE

18.1 Mixing Genres and Modes
18.2 Multimodal Trailblazer: Torika Bolatagici
18.3 Glance at Genre: Genre, Audience, Purpose, Organization
18.4 Annotated Sample Reading: "Celebrating a Win-Win" by Alexandra Dapolito Dunn
18.5 Writing Process: Create a Multimodal Advocacy Project
18.6 Evaluation: Transitions
18.7 Spotlight on . . . Technology
18.8 Portfolio: Multimodalism

INTRODUCTION Chances are you already have a great deal of experience with **multimodal** composition—that is, writing or creating content by combining different types of communication. Much of your experience may come from digital spaces, perhaps even from platforms such as social media that you don't associate with academics. According to literature examining adolescent and young adult literacy skills, young adults incorporate a great deal of multimodal communication—which includes sound, images, movement, and text—into their everyday lives to express themselves and connect with others. Social media has no doubt hastened the spread of multimodal communication, and its prevalence in the world is unprecedented. Perhaps you have never believed that your experience with digital and multimodal writing connects to academic composition, but indeed it does. Just as technology has changed how people interact with the world, multimodal composition has altered how they create content. In this chapter, you will learn how to combine

your experience in creating and using multimodal composition with established writing practices, particularly those used in argumentative writing, to generate connected content that creates meaning.

Multimodal composition begins where any other composition does: with the **rhetorical situation**, or the circumstance of communication in which one person (the composer) uses communication to influence the perspective of another (the audience). All multimodal compositions are created for a specific time and place and a particular audience who views the world in an explicit and culturally influenced way. As a writer, you make choices based on the rhetorical situation: context, audience, purpose, genre, and culture. You consider the strengths and weaknesses of all the possible means and tools available for reaching your rhetorical goals. By identifying the audience, determining what you need to tell the audience, and analyzing the best way to do that (including which types of media to use), you are empowered to create an effective and targeted composition.

In many ways, multimodal composition opens a range of possibilities by offering you any number of tools to make meaning, rather than limiting you to text alone. For example, a sportswriter might rely heavily on visuals to engage readers and demonstrate a runner's prowess, or they might create infographics to relay statistics about the athlete or the meet itself.



FIGURE 18.2 Composers often use images to engage readers and relate details that are difficult to express with words alone. (credit: "ISST 2014 Munich" by R. Boed/flickr, CC BY 2.0)

Websites require a balance of text, images, and careful formatting to present information in ways that are easy to digest and not overwhelming for the reader. In fact, the most difficult part of this type of creation may be choosing among the available tools to create meaning *effectively* without doing too much or too little. In some ways, the flexibility of websites can make it hard to know where to get started—or where to end.

This chapter presents a blog post by Alexandra Dapolito Dunn, formerly of the Environmental Protection Agency. Studying this article and the components of multimodal writing that Dunn chooses to use will help you understand how different platforms and rhetorical needs require different elements of text, media, and modes. Later in the chapter, you will learn how to address a range of audiences through your own textual and digital compositions.

18.1 Mixing Genres and Modes

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Address a range of audiences using a variety of technologies.
- Adapt composing processes for a variety of modalities, including textual and digital compositions.
- Match the capacities of different print and electronic environments to varying rhetorical situations.

The writing genre for this chapter incorporates a variety of modalities. A **genre** is a type of composition that encompasses defined features, follows a style or format, and reflects your purpose as a writer. For example, given the composition types *romantic comedy*, *poetry*, or *documentary*, you probably can think easily of features of each of these composition types. When considering the multimodal genres, you will discover that genres create **conventions** (standard ways of doing things) for categorizing media according to the expectations of the audience and the way the media will be consumed. Consider film media, for example; it encompasses genres including drama, documentaries, and animated shorts, to name a few. Each genre has its own conventions, or features. When you write or analyze multimodal texts, it is important to account for genre conventions.

A note on text: typically, when referring to text, people mean written words. But in multimodal genres, the term *text* can refer to a piece of communication as a whole, incorporating written words, images, sounds, and even movement. The following images are examples of multimodal texts.

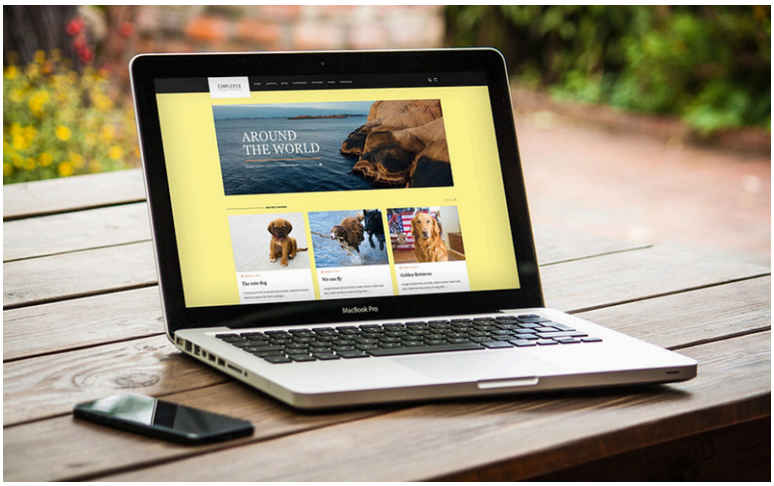


FIGURE 18.3 A website is a multimodal text that combines images and words. It may incorporate sound and animation as well. (credit: “SimplePix - Responsive WordPress Blog Magazine Theme #2” by Serge Kij/flickr, CC BY 2.0)



FIGURE 18.4 A theatrical performance, as shown in this dance image, is a multimodal text combining drama, music, movement, and visual design. Other theatrical performances combine different elements. (credit: "Danses d'Okinawa (musée Guimet, Paris)" by Jean-Pierre Dalbéra/flickr, CC BY 2.0)

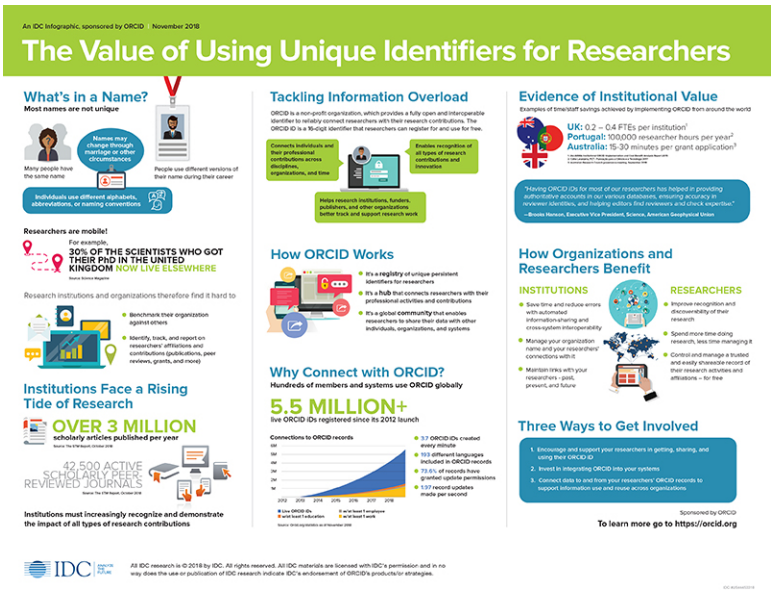


FIGURE 18.5 An infographic is a multimodal text that combines words and different types of graphics to convey information succinctly. (credit: "ORCID Infographic 2019" by ORCID/Wikimedia Commons, CC0)

Multimodal genres are uniquely positioned to address audiences through a variety of **modes**, or types of communication. These can be identified in the following categories:

Linguistic text: The most common mode for writing, the linguistic mode includes written or spoken text.

Visuals: The visual mode includes anything the reader can see, including images, colors, lighting, typefaces, lines, shapes, and backgrounds.

Audio: The audio mode includes all types of sound, such as narration, sound effects, music, silence, and ambient noise.

Spatial: Especially important in digital media, the spatial mode includes spacing, image and text size and

position, white space, visual organization, and alignment.

Gestural: The gestural mode includes communication through all kinds of body language, including movement and facial expressions.

Multimodal composition provides an opportunity for you to develop and practice skills that will translate to future coursework and career opportunities. Creating a multimodal text requires you to demonstrate aptitude in various modes and reflects the requirements for communication skills beyond the academic world. In other words, although multimodal creations may seem to be little more than pictures and captions at times, they must be carefully constructed to be effective. Even the simplest compositions are meticulously planned and executed. Multimodal compositions may include written text, such as blog post text, slideshow text, and website content; image-based content, such as infographics and photo essays; or audiovisual content, including podcasts, public service announcements, and videos.



FIGURE 18.6 Multimodal compositions aren't always complicated. Even a single photo can create a major impact on readers. (credit: "3-187 Infantry soldier scanning ridge in Bak Defense" by Sgt. Jeffrey Alexander/Wikimedia Commons, Defense.gov Photo Essays, Public Domain)

Multimodal composition is especially important in a 21st-century world where communication must represent and transfer across cultural contexts. Because using multiple modes helps a writer make meaning in different **channels** (media that communicate a message), the availability of different modes is especially important to help you make yourself understood as an author. In academic settings, multimodal content creation increases engagement, improves equity, and helps prepare you to be a global citizen. The same is true for your readers. Multimodal composition is important in addressing and supporting cultural and linguistic diversity. Modes are shaped by social, cultural, and historic factors, all of which influence their use and impact in communication. And it isn't just readers who benefit from multimodal composition. Combining a variety of modes allows you as a composer to connect to your own lived experiences—the representation of experiences and choices that you have faced in your own life—and helps you develop a unique voice, thus leveraging your knowledge and experiences.



18.2 Trailblazer

Multimodal Trailblazer: Torika Bolatagici

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Identify various rhetorical and culture contexts while reading for inquiry, learning, critical thinking, and communication.
- Demonstrate that genre conventions vary and are shaped by purpose, culture, and expectation.



FIGURE 18.7 Torika Bolatagici (https://openstax.org/r/4S3YIw-PFAs) works to bring attention to indigenous artists. Speculation exists as to the origin of this wall- like stone structure; some believe it was constructed by early peoples of Australia. (credit: "Man-made stone wall" by Rupert Gerritsen/Wikimedia Commons, CC0).

"I can never deny the deeply personal place that the work comes from."

Digital Representations of Embodiment and Cultural Identity

Torika Bolatagici is a creator, educator, and art historian who works with various modalities, including photography (https://openstax.org/r/photography), video, fine art, and mixed media (https://openstax.org/r/mixed_media). Bolatagici was born in Tasmania and, as a young person, spent time living in Hobart, Tasmania; Sydney, Australia; and her father's village of Suvavou, Fiji. Her work has been featured across the globe, including in exhibits in the United States, Taiwan, and Mexico as well as throughout New Zealand and Australia. She has a PhD from the School of Art and Design, University of New South Wales, where she wrote her dissertation on "Somatic Sotia: Commodity, Agency and the Fijian Military Body."

In 2013 and 2014, Bolatagici coordinated the Contemporary Pacific Arts Festival (https://openstax.org/r/contemporary_specific), curating an experience that focused on Pacific arts practices in Australia. She invited speakers to present on themes spanning activism and the arts, cultural appropriation, and contemporary artistic practices. Bolatagici now works as an educator, lecturing on art and performance at Deakin University in Australia, and has led youth arts workshops in the local Pacific community.

Reflecting on the beginnings of her career, she describes going through her undergraduate coursework and feeling the responsibility of bringing "brown-ness" to the classroom. After finding that higher education largely dismissed the lived experiences of marginalized communities and spending time at the Stuart Hall Library at the Institute of International Visual Arts, Bolatagici was inspired to create the pop-up Community Reading Room in Melbourne, Australia, in 2013.

Through the pop-up room, she hoped to engage the community in international visual arts and culture. She began her initiative by sharing her own personal collection, including texts and anthologies of BIPOC (Black, Indigenous, and people of color) art. The Community Reading Room provides an emphasis on contemporary art and theory from Africa, the Americas, and Oceania.

Bolatagici has incorporated a variety of media (https://openstax.org/r/variety) into her academic and professional portfolios, describing how her work helps her not only represent diverse cultures (https://openstax.org/r/represent) but also explore her own identity. From photo essays (https://openstax.org/r/photo_essays) to academic papers, her compositions are anchored by the common thread of representing marginalized people and experiences, particularly those related to communities of color. Her creative output has focused on representation of mixed-race identity, Pacific arts practices, and militarism. Through mixed media, she investigates relationships between visual culture and historiography (study of historical writings); human ecology (study of relationships between humans and their natural, social, and created environments); and the intersection of gender, knowledge, and globalization.

Bolatagici describes her work as interdisciplinary, creating components across a wide range of media. Instead of limiting herself, she allows her work to flow naturally, staying focused in the moment. With these unique components, she looks at the relationship between visual culture and human ecology. This interdisciplinary approached emerged for Bolatagici even before she knew it as multimodalism. Because her interests in college varied so greatly, she pursued a media arts degree so that she could explore visual arts as they related to cultural studies. This pursuit grew into a career that now includes new modes and media sources, such as photography, video, and mixed media.

Choosing a multimodal approach because it better communicates the complex subjects she conveys, Bolatagici draws on her own experiences in order to represent the experiences of marginalized people at the forefront of her compositions. For Bolatagici, creating in any form is bigger than the page, and she aims to bring her reality to life through visual, textual, and multimedia creations that communicate in four dimensions.

Read Bolatagici's weekly journal (https://openstax.org/r/freshmilk) during her residency in Barbados.

Discussion Questions

1. How does using a multimodal approach allow Bolatagici to communicate her lived experience?
2. Why does representation matter in multimodal composition? How has Bolatagici addressed this in her methods?
3. What role can multimodal compositions play in exploring experiences beyond your own?
4. How can multimodal works at times better communicate aspects of culture and history than literary text alone?
5. In what sense is bringing communities together an important aspect of Bolatagici's work?

18.3 Glance at Genre: Genre, Audience, Purpose, Organization

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Identify key genre conventions, including structure, tone, and mechanics.
- Implement common formats and design features for different text types.
- Demonstrate how genre conventions vary and are shaped by purpose, culture, and expectation.

The multimodal genres of writing are based on the idea that modes work in different ways, with different outcomes, to create various vehicles for communication. By layering, or combining, modes, an author can

make meaning and communicate through mixed modes what a single mode cannot on its own. Essentially, modes "cooperate" to communicate the author's intent as they interweave meanings captured by each.

For example, think of a public service announcement about environmental conservation. A composer can create a linguistic text about the dangers of plastic pollution in oceans and support the ideas with knowledge of or expertise in the subject. Yet words alone may not communicate the message forcefully, particularly if the audience consists of people who have never considered the impact of pollution on the oceans. That composer, then, might combine the text with images of massive amounts of human-generated plastic waste littering a shoreline, thus strengthening the argument and enhancing meaning by touching on audience emotions. By using images to convey some of the message, the composer layers modes. The picture alone does not tell the whole story, but when combined with informational text, it enhances the viewer's understanding of the issue. Modes, therefore, can be combined in various ways to communicate a rhetorical idea effectively.



FIGURE 18.8 The addition of various types of media can enhance the impact of a composition and thus increase the reader's understanding of an issue. (credit: "Polluted Beach on the Red Sea in Sharm el-Naga, Port Safaga, Egypt" by Vberger/Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain)

Audience Awareness

As with any type of composition, knowing your **audience** (the readers and viewers for whom you are creating) will help you determine what information to include and what genre, mode(s), or media in which to present it. Consider your audience when choosing a composition's **tone** (composer's attitude toward the audience or subject), substance, and language. Considering the audience is critical not only in traditional academic writing but also in nearly any genre or mode you choose. Ask yourself these questions when analyzing your audience's awareness:

- What (and how much) does the audience already know about the topic? The amount of background information needed can influence what genre, modes, and media types you include and how you use them. You don't want to bore an audience with information that is common knowledge or overwhelm an audience with information they know nothing about.
- What is the audience's viewpoint on the subject? Are you creating for a skeptical audience or one that

largely agrees with your rhetorical arguments?
- How do you relate to your audience? Do you share cultural understanding, or are you presenting information or beliefs that will be unfamiliar? This information will help you shape the message, tone, and structure of the composition.

Understanding your audience allows you to choose rhetorical devices that reflect **ethos** (appeals to ethics: credibility), **logos** (appeals to logic: reason), and **pathos** (appeals to sympathy: emotion) to create contextually responsive compositions through multiple modes.



It important to address audience diversity in all types of composition, but the unique aspects of multimodal composition present particular opportunities and challenges. First, when you compose, you do so through your own cultural filter, formed from your experiences, gender, education, and other factors. Multimodal composition opens up the ability to develop your cultural filter through various methods. Think about images of your lived experiences, videos capturing cultural events, or even gestures in live performances. Also consider the diversity of your audience members and how that affects the content choices you make during composition. Avoiding **ethnocentrism**—the assumption that the customs, values, and beliefs of your culture are superior to others—is an important consideration when addressing your audience, as is using bias-free language, especially regarding ethnicity, gender, and abilities.

Blogs, Vlogs, and Creative Compositions

Among the modes available to you as a composer, **blogs** (regularly updated websites, usually run by an individual or a small group) have emerged as a significant genre in digital literature. The term *blog*, a combination of *web* and *log*, was coined in 1999 and gained rapid popularity in the early 2000s. In general, blogs have a relatively narrow focus on a topic or argument and present a distinctive structure that includes these features:

- A headline or title draws in potential readers. Headlines are meant to grab attention, be short, and accurately reflect the content of the blog post.
- An introduction hooks the reader, briefly introducing the topic and establishing the author's credibility on the subject.
- Short paragraphs often are broken up by images, videos, or other media to make meaning and supplement or support the text content.
- The narrative is often composed in a style in which the author claims or demonstrates expertise.
- Media such as images, video, and infographics depict information graphically and break up text.
- Hyperlinks (links to other internet locations) to related content often serve as evidence supporting the author's claim.
- A call to action provides clear and actionable instructions that engage the reader.

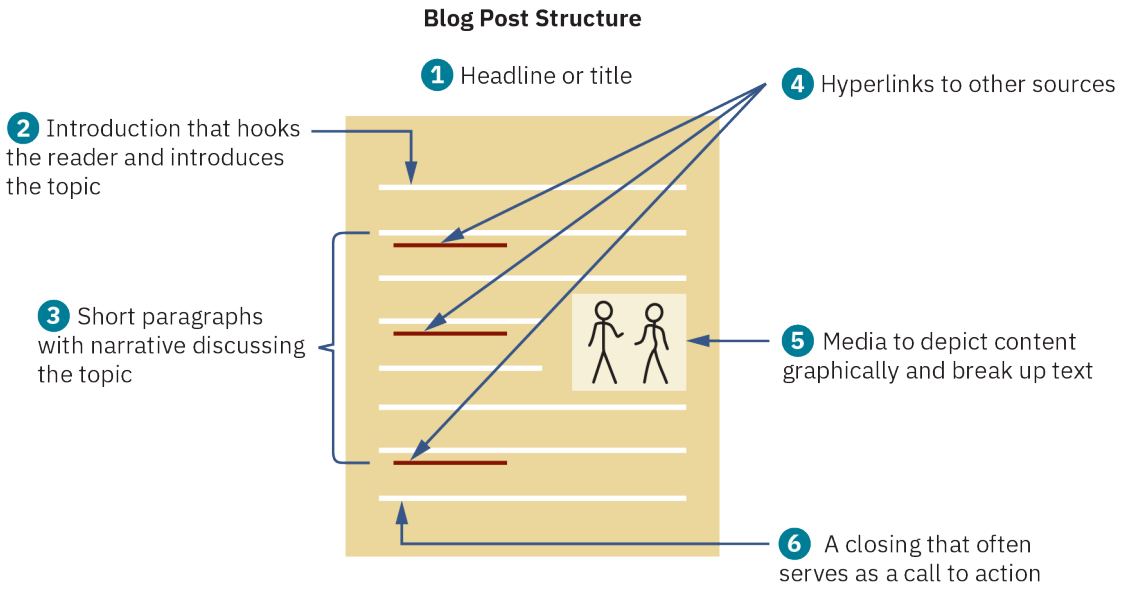


FIGURE 18.9 A blog post typically has these labeled parts. (attribution: Copyright Rice University, OpenStax, under CC BY NC-SA 4.0 license)

Blogs offer accessibility and an opportunity to make meaning in new ways. By integrating images and audiovisual media, you can develop a multimodal representation of arguments and ideas. Blogs also provide an outlet for conveying ideas through both personal and formal narratives and are used frequently in industries from entertainment to scientific research to government organizations.

Newer in the family of multimodal composition is the video blog, or **vlog**, a blog for which the medium is video. Vlogs usually combine video embedded in a website with supporting text, images, or other modes of communication. Vlogging often takes on a narrative structure, similar to other types of storytelling, with the added element of supplementary audio and video, including digital transitions that connect one idea or scene to another. Vlogs offer ample opportunities to mix modalities.

Vlogs give a literal *voice* to a composer, who typically narrates or speaks directly to the camera. Like a blogger, a vlog creator acts as an expert, telling a narrative story or using rhetoric to argue a point. Vlogs often strive to create an authentic and informal tone, similar to published blogs, inviting a stream-of-consciousness or interview-like style. Therefore, they often work well when targeted toward audiences for whom a casual mood is valuable and easily understood.



FIGURE 18.10 Vlogs are video blogs that offer the opportunity for composers to voice their thoughts in a stream-of-

consciousness style or interview-like style. (credit: "BloggerCon IV Day 2 24Jun06 – 13" by Roland Tanglao/flickr, CC0 1.0)

Other creative compositions include websites, digital or print newsletters, podcasts, and a wide variety of other content. Each composition type has its own best practices regarding structure and organization, often depending on the chosen modalities, the way they are used, and the intended audience. Whatever the mode, however, all multimodal writing has several characteristics in common, beginning with effective, intentional composition.

Effective Writing

Experimenting with modes and media is not an excuse for poorly developed writing that lacks focus, organization, thought, purpose, or attention to mechanics. Although multimodal compositions offer flexibility of expression, the content still must be presented in well-crafted, organized, and purposeful ways that reflect the author's purpose and the audience's needs.

- To be well-crafted, a composition should reflect the author's use of literary devices to convey meaning, use of relevant connections, and acknowledgment of grammar and writing conventions.
- To be organized, a composition should reflect the author's use of effective transitions and a logical structure appropriate to the chosen mode.
- To be purposeful, a composition should show that the author addresses the needs of the audience, uses rhetorical devices that advance the argument, and offers insightful understanding of the topic.

Organization of multimodal compositions refers to the sequence of message elements. You must decide which ideas require attention, how much and in what order, and which modalities create maximum impact on readers. While many types of formal and academic writing follow a prescribed format, or at least the general outline of one, the exciting and sometimes overwhelming features of multimodal possibilities open the door to any number of acceptable formats. Some of these are prescribed, and others more open ended; your job will inevitably be to determine when to follow a template and when to create something new. As the composer, you seek to structure media in ways that will enable the reader, or audience, to derive meaning. Even small changes in media, rhetorical appeal, and organization can alter the ways in which the audience participates in the construction of meaning.




Within a medium—for example, a video—you might include images, audio, and text. By shifting the organization, placement, and interaction among the modes, you change the structure of the video and therefore create varieties of meaning. Now, imagine you use that same structure of images, audio, and text, but change the medium to a slideshow. The impact on the audience will likely change with the change in medium. Consider the infamous opening scene of the horror movie *The Shining* (1980). The primary medium, video, shows a car driving through a mountainous region. After audio is added, however, the meaning of the multimodal composition changes, creating an emphasis on pace—management of dead air—and tone—attitude toward the subject—that communicates something new to the audience.



FIGURE 18.11 The opening scenes of *The Shining* feature the serene-looking Saint Mary Lake with its Wild Goose

Island. The addition of the audio mode, music featuring ominous-sounding horns (https://openstax.org/r/ominous), not only communicates new information to viewers but also shapes an emphasis on drama and danger. (credit: "The upper end of St. Mary Lake and Wild Goose Island, Glacier National Park, Montana. Photo taken from Going-to-the-Sun Road" by Ken Thomas/Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain)

Exploring the Genre

These are the key terms and characteristics of multimodal texts.

- **Alignment:** the way in which elements such as text features, images, and particularly text are placed on a page. Text can be aligned at the left, center, or right. Alignment contributes to organization and how media transitions within a text.
- **Audience:** readers or viewers of the composition.
- **Channel:** a medium used to communicate a message. Often-used channels include websites, blogs, social media, print, audio, and video-hosting sites.
- **Complementary:** describes content that is different across two or more modes, both of which are necessary for understanding. Often audio and visual modes are complementary, with one making the other more meaningful.
- **Emphasis:** the elements in media that are most significant or pronounced. The emphasis choices have a major impact on the overall meaning of the text.
- **Focus:** a clear purpose for composition, also called the central idea, main point, or guiding principle. Focus should include the specific audience the composer is trying to influence.
- **Layering:** combining modes in a single composition.
- **Layout:** the organization of elements on a page, including text, images, shapes, and overall composition. Layout applies primarily to the visual mode.
- **Media:** the means and channels of reaching an audience (for example, image, website, song). A medium (singular form of *media*) can contain multiple modes.
- **Mode:** the method of communication (linguistic, visual, audio, or spatial means of creating meaning). Media can incorporate more than one mode.
- **Organization:** the pattern of arrangement that allows a reader to understand text or images in a composition. Organization may be textual, visual, or spatial.
- **Proximity:** the relationship between objects in space, specifically how close to or far from one another they are. Proximity can show a relationship between elements and is often important in layout.
- **Purpose:** an author's reason for writing a text, including the reasoning that accounts for which modes of presentation to use. Composers of multimodal texts may seek to persuade, inform, or entertain the audience.
- **Repetition:** a unifying feature, such as a pattern used more than once, in the way in which elements (text features, typeface, color, etc.) are used on a page. Repetition often indicates emphasis or a particular theme. Repetitions and patterns can help focus a composition, explore a theme, and emphasize important points.
- **Supplementary:** describes content that is different in two or more modes, where a composer uses one mode to convey primary understanding and the other(s) to support or extend understanding. Supplementary content should not be thought of as "extra," for its purpose is to expand on the primary media.
- **Text:** written words. In multimodal composition, text can refer to a piece of communication as a whole, incorporating written words, images, sounds, and movement.
- **Tone:** the composer's attitude toward the subject and/or the audience.
- **Transitions:** words, phrases, or audiovisual elements that help readers make connections between ideas in a multimodal text, including connections from sentence to sentence, paragraph to paragraph, and mode to mode. Transitions show relationships between ideas and help effectively organize a composition.

18.4 Annotated Sample Reading: “Celebrating a Win-Win” by Alexandra Dapolito Dunn

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Read a diverse range of texts in different genres to identify how conventions are shaped by purpose, language, culture, and audience expectation.
- Read effectively for inquiry, learning, critical thinking, and communication in various rhetorical and cultural contexts.
- Demonstrate the relationships between ideas, patterns of organization, and verbal and nonverbal elements.

Introduction

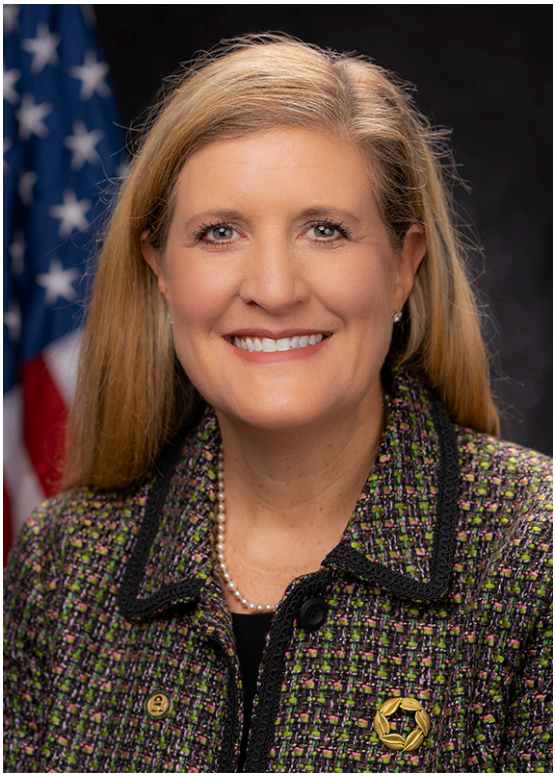


FIGURE 18.12 Alexandra Dapolito Dunn (credit: “Alex Dunn, assistant administrator at US EPA” by Eric Vance/ Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain)

As a multimodal composer, you may choose to employ ethos, a rhetorical method of persuasion. In this context, ethos is an appeal to readers in order to establish the author’s credibility and character. In a rhetorical appeal, you can use ethos through fair, neutral language to show trustworthiness. In multimodal composition, ethos aims to convince readers that you are a reliable and an ethical expert on the subject. When using ethos, authors present sources that support their argument in balanced and honest ways, revealing their writing to be reliable. Authors also seek to understand their audience, establishing commonalities between those who support the issue, those who are undecided or indifferent, and those who dissent. Often, authors invoke the words or ideas of respected figures, authorities, or even religious texts when using ethos to convince readers. Analyzing multimodal compositions can help you learn how to use rhetorical frames in the multimodal composing process. In the blog post you are about to read, the author uses ethos, along with structural aspects of multimodal texts, to establish herself as a trustworthy expert on the subject of pollution prevention. Studying the components of multimodal writing in this blog will help you understand how multimedia platforms utilize elements of text, media, and modes.

LIVING BY THEIR OWN WORDS

"Celebrating a Win-Win: 30 Years of Progress under the Pollution Prevention Act" by Alexandra Dapolito Dunn (b. 1967)

> On this day in 1990, a new era was ushered in for Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) and the nation when the Pollution Prevention (P2) Act was signed into law. The act gave the agency new tools to join with states, tribes, and communities to prevent pollution *before* it happens. It also marked a shift in the paradigm of environmental protection, which had been mostly focused on end-of-pipe pollution control and clean-up strategies.

Headline and Tone. *The linguistic headline immediately allows readers to know the author's position on the subject, and its visual component of boldfaced text allows readers to understand that it's important. Not only does it clearly preface the article by informing the reader of its topic (the Pollution Prevention Act), but it also presents the author's positive attitude toward the subject through the words celebrating and win-win.*

Context. *Dunn contextualizes the Pollution Prevention Act, showing it as a positive national achievement that partnered the government with the people to prevent pollution.*

> Equally important, the P2 Act strengthened EPA's role as an ally of American businesses, helping them save billions of dollars and improve operations. As EPA Administrator Andrew Wheeler has said, "It's far better to prevent pollution from occurring than to go in after the fact and clean it up."

Quotation from an Authority. *This quotation from the EPA administrator supports Dunn's assertion that the P2 Act is good for America. The quotation helps lend credibility to the author's claim that the P2 Act has been a success over the past 30 years.*

Purpose. *Dunn's purpose is to show how the P2 Act has been successful over time. Thus far, she has supported the claims that it has improved the environment and helped local governments and private businesses.*

> The P2 Act greatly expanded the opportunities for "source reduction" to reduce or prevent pollution at the source through cost-effective changes in production, operation, and raw materials use. These changes can reduce the amount of pollution entering a waste stream or the environment prior to recycling, treatment or disposal, and can offer industry substantial savings in reduced raw material, pollution control, pollution clean-up and liability costs.

Short Paragraphs. *Dunn uses short, easily digestible paragraphs in her blog post. Short paragraphs are visually effective on a screen and ensure that the reader is not overwhelmed by text while helping the writer organize ideas.*

Ethos. *Dunn uses neutral, measured language to convince the reader that she is a reliable and ethical expert.*

> One of EPA's first pollution prevention successes was with its 33/50 Program, a voluntary program under which companies committed to reduce their releases of 17 top priority chemicals 33 percent by 1992 and by 50 percent by 1995. Subsequent EPA programs built on the 33/50 and P2 model and are still working to reduce pollution across the country today including EPA's WaterSense (https://openstax.org/r/watersense), Safer Choice (https://openstax.org/r/safer_choice), Environmentally Preferable Purchasing (https://openstax.org/r/environmentally), Green Chemistry (https://openstax.org/r/green), and our SmartWay Transport Partnership Program (https://openstax.org/r/smartway). President Trump acknowledged the effectiveness of these and other EPA programs in a 2018 Executive Order that directed federal agencies to use EPA's P2 resources to meet their statutory sustainable purchasing requirements.

Hyperlinks. *Hyperlinks are a functional tool and employ the visual mode to command the reader's attention. Dunn uses hyperlinks to the EPA programs she names, establishing the agency as a source of pollution prevention efforts and, as a result, an expert on the issues covered in the blog post. In addition, she links to the presidential executive*

order, which establishes credibility.

> The P2 Act also serves as an authority for collecting information from reporting facilities through the Toxics Release Inventory (https://openstax.org/r/toxics) (TRI) about their management of certain toxic chemicals, including source reduction approaches. Since this reporting began in 1991, we have learned that over 24,000 unique facilities have taken more than 450,000 actions to prevent pollution and reduce the amount of toxic chemicals entering the environment, such as spill and leak prevention measures, using safer chemicals, modifying industrial processes, and updating operating procedures.

Transition between Paragraphs. *By using the word also, Dunn signals that she is shifting to another success the EPA has achieved in preventing pollution.*

Statistics as Supporting Evidence. *To support the impact of the P2 Act, Dunn uses statistics as evidence to show that the act has facilitated the prevention of pollution and toxic chemicals.*

> Perhaps the most impactful and collaborative program to grow out of the P2 Act is EPA's P2 Grants Program. Since 1990, EPA has awarded more than 1,200 grants to state, tribal, non-profit, and university partners to work directly with U.S. businesses to develop and implement source reduction techniques. With the assistance from P2 grants, businesses have been able to save over $1.5 billion since 2011 while also reducing the use of hazardous materials by over 570 million pounds.

Supporting Evidence. *Dunn provides evidence of the success of the P2 Act by showing how one program has helped local governments and private businesses save money.*

> As we celebrate the 30th anniversary of the Pollution Prevention Act today, I would like to thank all our state and local pollution prevention partners, as well as all the businesses that have joined with us to score a true win-win for the American people.

Audience. *Although this blog is written on a public government website, Dunn shifts focus at the end to directly address businesses and local governments that have partnered with her or her organization.*

You can access this post on the EPA blog (https://openstax.org/r/win-win).

Discussion Questions

1. Why does Dunn choose to use neutral language rather than emotional appeals in this blog post?
2. Why does Dunn focus on the impact of the P2 Act on businesses, particularly on how the act is financially beneficial to those organizations?
3. How might this blog post differ if the intended audience were different?
4. What is the effect of Dunn's shift to addressing specific partners at the end of the post?
5. In your opinion, does Dunn effectively establish herself as a trusted source? Why or why not?

18.5 Writing Process: Create a Multimodal Advocacy Project

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Craft textual and digital compositions using various genres of modes and technologies.
- Match different modes of communication to various rhetorical situations.
- Identify various genres of multimodal and online writing.

Now you will experiment with using multiple modes to create an advocacy project. An advocacy project tells the story of an overarching problem—for example, world hunger—and uses multiple modalities to inform readers about that issue and to propose change. You may be familiar with similar advocacy projects; perhaps

you have been involved with them in your everyday life. Think carefully about advocacy initiatives you know of or have encountered, and find out whether you can pinpoint the answers to these three questions: *What problem is being addressed? Who is the intended audience? What mode or modes are being used, including what media?* Then think about what works. *How do the chosen media speak to the specific audience? Why might the initiative's creators have made those choices?*

After you have chosen a cause and begun working through the composition, you might want to tweak the modes you are working with, including how they relate to one another. You may find, for example, that your primary communication to readers would be better achieved with a different mode or that you need stronger transitions to move your reader through your rhetorical appeal. Don't be afraid to experiment, revise, and examine your project from different angles. Just like a literary text, a multimodal composition is a living document, one that can be improved over time with peer review and revision. As you work, focus your project by concentrating on addressing your audience, purpose, and organization.

Summary of Assignment

Create a multimodal advocacy project for a cause or an issue that you choose or that your instructor chooses for you. If you are free to choose your own topic, here is a short list from which you may draw inspiration:

- Providing clean and safe water
- Ending gun violence
- Addressing nutritional needs of children locally or around the world
- Anti-bullying
- Reducing your carbon footprint
- Access to health care
- Anti-racism
- Vaccination policies
- Social media and free speech
- Climate change
- Immigration

You may also use these brainstorming questions to narrow down your topic:

- What are you passionate about?
- Where do you notice a need in your community / the world?
- What ideas do you have for addressing the issue?
- What existing campaigns do you find compelling, and why?
- What existing projects can you build on, and how?
- What goals do you hope to achieve?

Choose a need or an issue that is important to you, because you will develop a rhetorical appeal to inform and convince your audience. Although world hunger is an important issue and may not be a bad example, consider choosing problems that you encounter locally, even in your everyday life. The closer you are to the issue, the more easily you will be able to develop rhetorical appeals. As you compose your project, consider the best modes and methods to communicate your ideas. Consider how to add and combine different modalities to increase audience impact without overdoing it.



FIGURE 18.13 As you brainstorm potential topics for your advocacy project, consider issues that directly impact your community as a starting point. (credit: "Blog Camp 2017" by gdsteam/flickr, CC BY 2.0)

Another Lens 1. To broaden your perspective on advocacy, find ways to connect directly to those whom the issue most closely affects. Ensure that your proposed advocacy provides pragmatic and helpful solutions to the problem for the targeted audience. For example, if you choose to create a project based on the need for education opportunities for young mothers who have survived domestic abuse, advocating for full-time schooling options with no consideration for childcare would be neither pragmatic nor helpful. In other words, don't assume you know best. Open yourself to information gleaned from research, interviews, or informal conversation. If possible, try to speak with someone whom your project will affect.

Determine what others are already doing to address the need you have identified, and decide whether to build on that work or take a different route. Identify the most effective means of translating the vision you decide on for your audience, which may differ from the audience targeted by other advocacy groups.

Another Lens 2. Another option for approaching this project is to identify and analyze multimodal advocacy initiatives already occurring on a large scale today. Some well-known ones include Charity: Water (https://openstax.org/r/water), Free Rice (https://openstax.org/r/rice), It Gets Better (https://openstax.org/r/it_gets), and Upworthy (https://openstax.org/r/upworthy). After choosing an advocacy campaign to research, consider the following:

- What is the purpose of the advocacy initiative? What do the organizers want to achieve?
- Whom does the initiative address? (Knowing the target audience will help you analyze how effectively the organizers use a multimodal approach to reach them.)
- How does the initiative persuade its audience? Are rhetorical appeals used, and if so, how? Why do you think these choices are made?
- What modes of communication are being used? (These may include social media platforms and streams.) Does the campaign rely more on textual or non-textual media to convey its message? How are modes combined, and how effective are these choices?

After thinking about these questions, create an addition to this advocacy initiative. Introduce your composition by explaining what you have included and why.



FIGURE 18.14 Look to successful advocacy projects, such as the It Gets Better Campaign (https://openstax.org/r/ItGetsBetter) supported by former President Barack Obama, as a model of the potential for incorporating multimodal elements into your project. (credit: "President Barack Obama" by Official White House Photo by Pete Souza/Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain)

Quick Launch: Defining a Primary Purpose and Goal

After you have decided on your topic, the first step is to identify the primary **purpose**, or reason, for your advocacy project. Your goal is what you want to accomplish with it. Do you intend to inform people about an issue they are likely to know little about, or do you want to inspire people around you to take action in creating a sustainable solution that addresses the issue at hand? Goals are broad statements and can be general and abstract, as in the case of this goal: *Improve access to clean water for students in Flint, Michigan.*

Part of identifying your goal is to articulate your **claim**, or assertion, about the issue you have chosen. Your claim is equivalent to a thesis in a traditional written essay. Identifying your purpose and goal will help you decide how to structure your project and, ultimately, which media and modes to employ.

Consider also your audience. You already have learned and discussed the importance of understanding your audience's perspective, including social, cultural, or linguistic factors that could affect your communication. Understanding what your audience knows, their lived experiences, and what is important to them will help you shape your narrative. Complete these sentence starters to organize your ideas and begin the planning stages of your project.

Define the situation.

My project focuses on _____, which is a problem because _____.

Define your purpose.

The purpose of my project is to _____, which will be accomplished by _____.

Write a thesis, hypothesis, or line of inquiry.

The issue I'm addressing is _____.

My position on the issue is _____.

Write your thesis as a declarative sentence. See Writing Process: Creating a Position Argument for help writing a thesis. _____.

Define your goals and objectives.

I will try to _____ by _____.

Define your audience.

The intended audience for my project is _____. They are _____ (familiar/unfamiliar) with the issue. I will reach them by _____.

After you define the situation, it is time to choose the mode or modes to communicate your ideas to your audience. For example, will you write an op-ed, or opinion piece, in which you formally discuss the issue and advocate for change? Will you write and deliver a speech that relies on rhetorical devices to convey your passion for the issue? You might also consider advertisements and public service announcements (PSAs), including audio and video versions, as other effective ways to "sell" a concept, often combining modes for added impact. For examples, peruse The Op-Ed Project (https://openstax.org/r/op-edproject) or the Ad Council (https://openstax.org/r/adcouncil).

Just as your choice of topic must be rhetorically sound and specific, your choice of mode should be based on the circumstances under which your audience will best meet and respond to your advocacy project. This decision may feel daunting, because composing within the multimodal genres means that you have many options. You might choose a video advertisement, a visual flyer, a performance, a photo essay, or something completely different. Consider the modes you might use to accomplish your goals, responding to the needs of your audience.

	Linguistic Mode	Visual Mode	Audio Mode	Spatial Mode	Gestural Mode
Uses in Composition	written text word choice organization tone	color style size perspective	sound narration music/effects silence	arrangement proximity organization	body language facial expressions
Primary Types of Media (media may cross multiple modes)	print or digital media (newspaper, blog, professional publication)	infographic photo essay advertisement PSA website/blog/vlog	speech advertisement radio podcast vlog	infographic photo essay website/blog/vlog	speech presentation vlog

TABLE 18.1

Drafting: Varying Purposes for Integration of Media or Other Genres

Once you have determined your purpose and audience and have considered the impact of including multiple modes and media, it is time to begin drafting your project.

Gathering Information

The first step in any project is to collect and analyze sources. You will likely need to explore relevant research, data, and literature that already address your topic. The following questions are a good place to start: *What do you already know about the issue you have chosen to address? What do you need to learn, and where can you find that information?*

When considering the data and research you read and collect, it is important to address multiple perspectives, particularly regarding culture, language, and social issues. It is essential to have a clear understanding of the needs of the community you seek to advocate for, as defined by that community.

Now plan for the ways in which your project will create and support the argument, the modes and media you will use, and how these will reach your audience. Start by completing a graphic organizer like Table 18.2. Begin with what you already know, including the sources of that information, formal research you have done, and informal or anecdotal data you have. After looking carefully at what you have, ask yourself what you still need to learn about the topic to understand and communicate the issue to your audience. Finally, brainstorm for strategies to learn that information. These may include research, interviews, or other methods of data collection. Then carry out that information collection until you have what you need.

What I already know	Source(s) of that information	Information and data that I need to collect	Where I can find information

TABLE 18.2 Planning Chart

Determine Modes and Media

Once your research is complete (or, at least, once you have a good enough foundation to get started), determine which modes and media you will employ to address your audience. Research, like composition as a whole, is largely an open-ended process, one in which you may need to experiment to determine whether the modes, media, and genres you choose accurately and effectively communicate your purpose to the audience. A good way to make this decision is to create a mockup or storyboard. A **mockup** is a visual representation of compositions that are basically static. You can use a mockup for media such as websites, posters, or photo essays. A **storyboard** is a sequence of drawings that represents the progression of a piece that moves through time. You can use a storyboard for media such as videos or podcasts.

Use graphic organizers like Figure 18.15 and Figure 18.16 for your mockup or storyboard. Remember to consider *all* modes, including linguistic, visual, audio, spatial, and gestural, and what impact they will make on your audience.

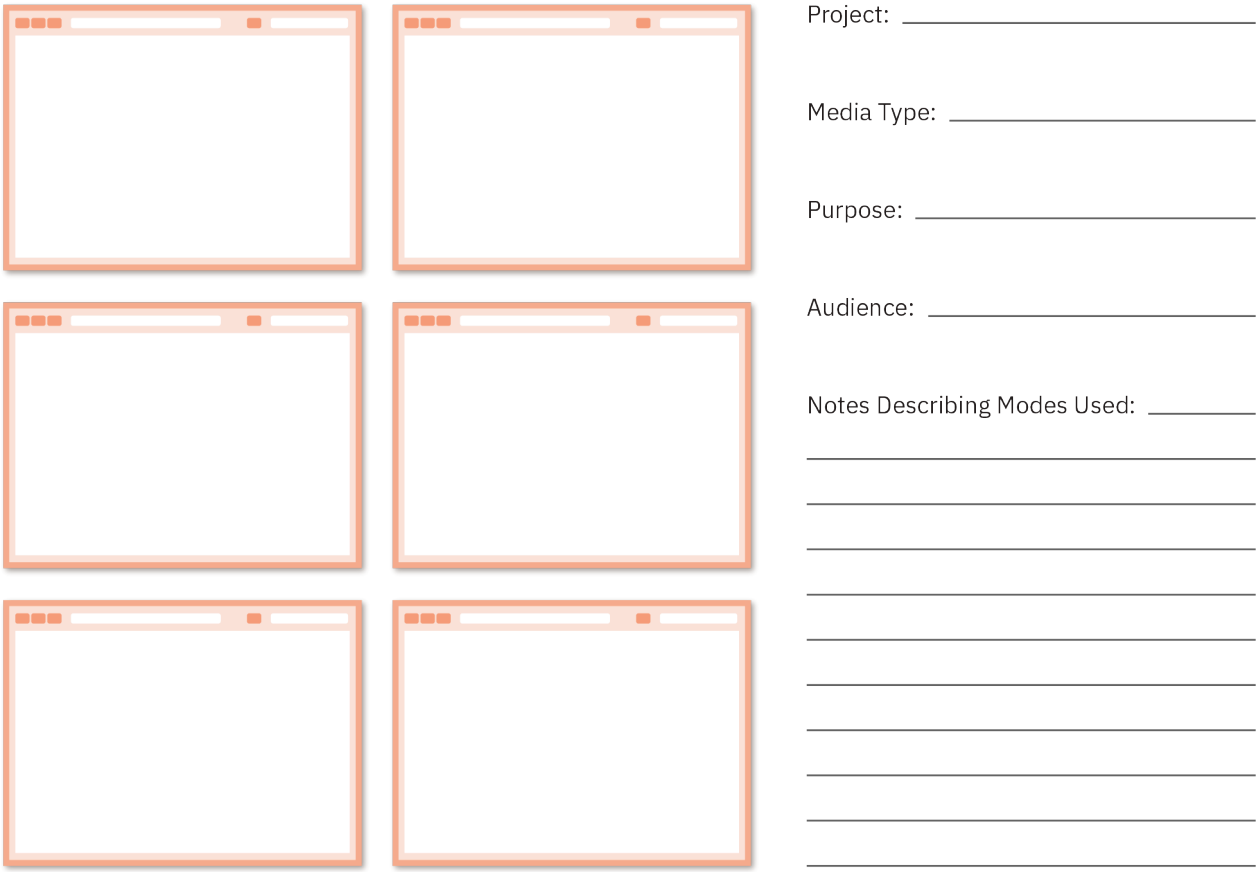


FIGURE 18.15 Mockup (attribution: Copyright Rice University, OpenStax, under CC BY NC-SA 4.0 license)

Project: _____ Media Type: _____

Purpose: _____ Audience: _____

FIGURE 18.16 Storyboard (attribution: Copyright Rice University, OpenStax, under CC BY NC-SA 4.0 license)

When you finish, look over your mockup or storyboard. Then consider whether your choices effectively address the needs of your audience. For example, a student composing a project calling for humanitarian efforts to improve the living conditions of citizens in war-torn Syria might choose the genre of a photo essay, with visual media and captions used as a powerful way to tell the story. This choice will be more effective than relying mainly on text or other means alone.



FIGURE 18.17 Destruction from the Syrian War (credit: "A destroyed part of Raqqa" by Mahmoud Bali/Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain)

That student might ask and answer questions such as the following:

- What do I want to convey? The desperate situation in Syria because of the war
- Who is my audience? Online readers interested in current events

- How do the media I've chosen speak to the audience? They tell a story more powerfully than text can by itself.

As you brainstorm, don't feel obligated to include every piece of information or media you collect. You'll want to choose carefully, ensuring that the information and media you use serve your audience and rhetorical goals.

Introduce Other Genres

After establishing the primary genre, it's time to define the purpose for introducing other genres, including how you will introduce them smoothly with seamless transitions. In the example above, the student chooses a photo essay as the primary genre. A photo essay usually includes multiple pictures, laid out on a blog or website with or without text. If there is an opportunity to directly address the audience, the student might consider writing a script to incorporate the genre of presentation. Or they might choose to create a slideshow or video, incorporating a voice-over or textual quotations. All of these choices depend on their purpose as the composer, the rhetorical methods they believe will work best, and a knowledge of their audience, including how best to respond to social and cultural needs. It's important not to incorporate more modes simply for the sake of having more. Each choice you make will either enhance or detract from your purpose.

Compose

Countless tools are available for creating multimodal texts. At first, this project may seem daunting as you ponder which tool to choose and possibly learn to use new technology. However, you will likely find you can use tools that are not only familiar but also readily available. Software and apps that you already have on your phone, tablet, or laptop, such as PowerPoint, Google Slides, and Keynote, not only are useful for slideshows but also allow you to create graphics and videos that you can upload to YouTube with a single click. You can record podcasts by using the memo feature on your phone or a free online recording tool and then upload them to SoundCloud.

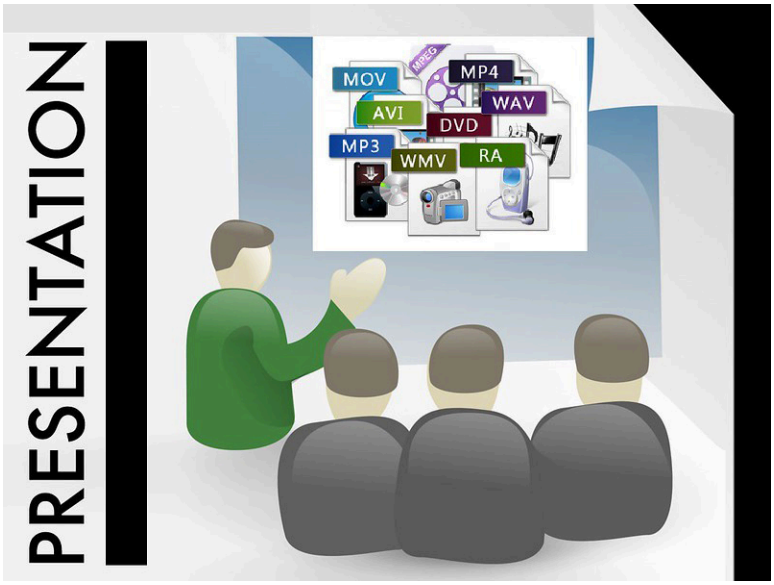


FIGURE 18.18 Finding tools to create a multimodal composition doesn't have to be difficult or complicated. Often, you are able to use familiar and readily available tools. (credit: "powerpoint-presentation in format video" by downloadsource.fr/flickr, CC BY 2.0)

After you have created your mockup or storyboard, it is time to create the first draft of your project. Sometimes called a *first cut*, particularly in audiovisual presentations, this is the next step in drafting the composition's basic elements. It is also your chance to experiment with the modes and media you have considered to determine what works and what doesn't. This first cut creates a **prototype**, a preliminary model or draft, that you will revise according to feedback from peer review. Consider this prototype as a starting point. Keep in

mind that the composition process, like the writing process, is **recursive**, not linear. You can move from drafting to research to revising and organizing at any point.

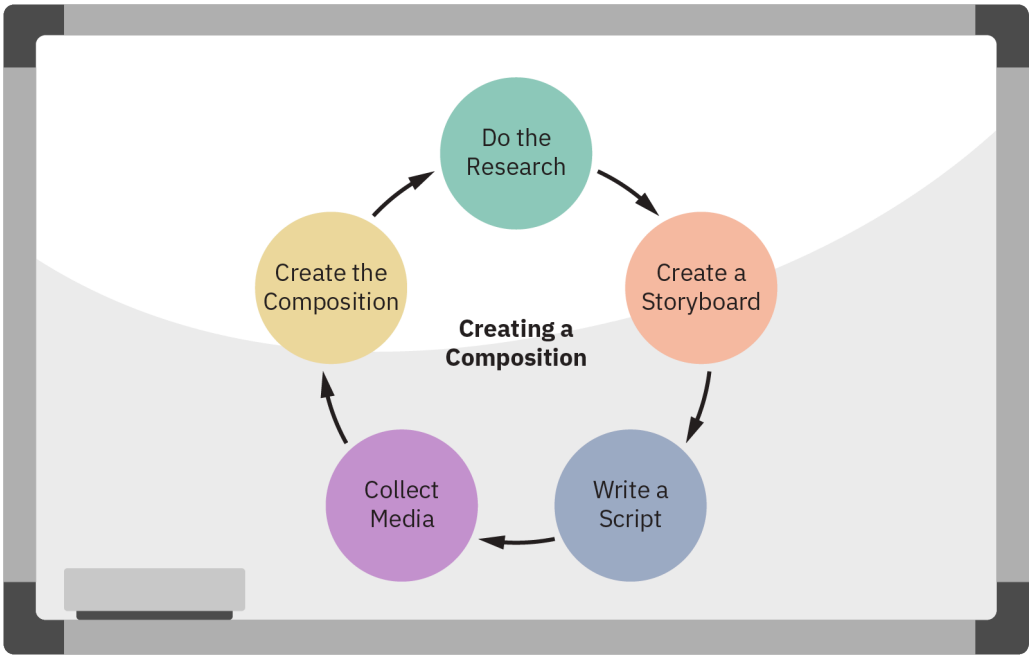


FIGURE 18.19 Like written composition, multimodal composition is a recursive process. (attribution: Copyright Rice University, OpenStax, under CC BY NC-SA 4.0 license)

Though your options for your project may seem endless, this is how the student drafted the photo essay about the war in Syria. Because the composition primarily uses the visual mode, the student created a mockup, which includes the photo from Figure 18.17 as well as other photos and shared information.



The second Battle of Raqqa occurred in 2017, with United States troops joining forces with the Syrian Democratic Forces to take control of the city. The battle began with multiple airstrikes that killed dozens of citizens and culminated months later after many more deaths. Over 80% of the city was left uninhabitable.

FIGURE 18.20 Sample mockup (credit: "SDF fighters in Raqqa downtown" by (top left), (top right) & (center right) Mahmoud Bali/Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain; (center left) Voice of America Kurdish/Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain; (bottom) United States Marine Corps/Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain)

As shown here, this mockup is basic; it contains only the photographs the author has chosen and a short textual excerpt that provides context and more information to support the image. Although there were other options for this photo essay, the student considered them and decided to use only images with some supporting text, basing this choice on purpose, audience, and organizational principles. As you consider your options, begin by focusing on one mode, then build a mockup according to your audience and purpose. The mockup may be as simple as an outline of a speech or a PowerPoint template to which you add text and images. The idea is to create a concrete piece to use for your prototype.

Creating the prototype is the next step. Remember that this is the stage at which you consider which elements of mode and media to use and put them "on the page." Keeping in mind the purpose, organization, and audience, design a prototype that meets those guiding principles.

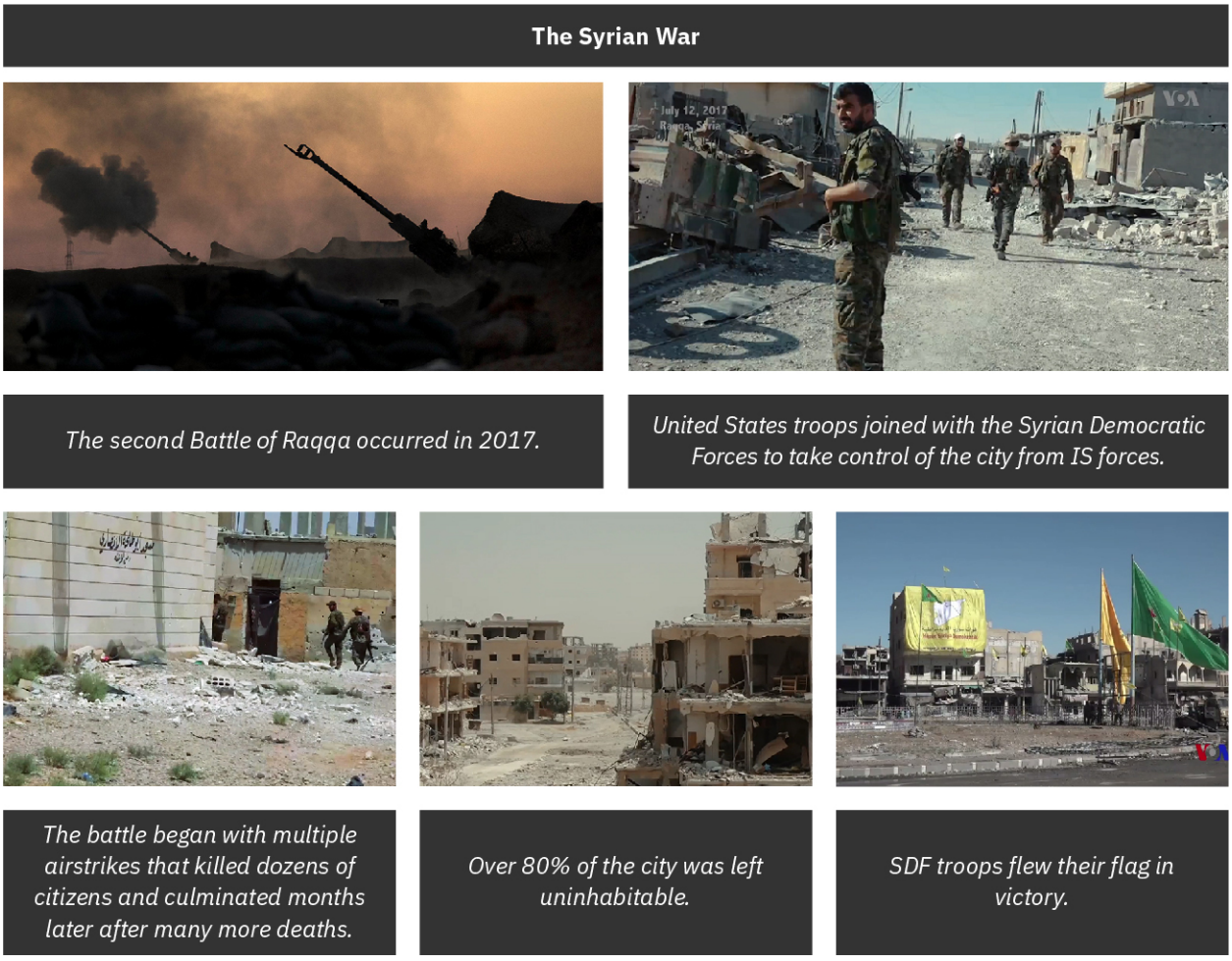


FIGURE 18.21 Sample prototype (credit: "SDF, YPG, and YPJ flags in Raqqa centre" by (top left) United States Marine Corps/Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain, (top right), (bottom left) & (bottom center) Mahmoud Bali/ Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain; (center right) Voice of America Kurdish/Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain)

For the prototype, the student made several choices related to the visual mode, incorporating both textual and graphic images. Remember that the composer stated an intent to convey the desperate situation in Syria resulting from war and is speaking to an audience of online readers interested in current events.

The first element added is a **headline**, "The Syrian War." It allows the reader to know immediately what the topic is and get a general idea of the context of the photo essay. The student has taken the text from the mockup and for each picture created a **caption**—a short statement that provides context for each event depicted and helps readers progress through the narrative of the photo essay. In addition, the composer has chosen to stage the captions against a black backdrop with white space between each photograph and caption, a visually appealing layout that is effective in its use of transitions. The images set against the black background stand out. Viewers can easily understand that they are supposed to read each row from left to right and understand the relationship between each picture and the one following it.

With these adjustments, the student has completed the prototype. It is now ready for peer review.

Peer Review: Asking Specific Questions of the Writer

Peer review is an important step in helping you determine the ways in which your multimodal composition works well and how it can be improved. Peer review allows you to gain an outside perspective on your writing and composing processes and thus makes it easier to clear up any questions related to organization, purpose, audience, and genre.

For your review, provide your peer reviewer with your mockup or storyboard and your prototype. Seeing your process may help your reviewer offer feedback and suggestions. Your peer reviewer can use the following questions to think critically about your project, focusing on both its strengths and its areas for improvement, and to guide their feedback. Your response to these questions will guide your revision process.

Questions about Topic

- How did you choose the focus of the composition?
- How did you narrow down the scope of your topic? Should it be broadened or narrowed further?

Questions about Purpose

- My reaction after reading or viewing the composition is _____ because _____. Does this reaction match your intent for the composition?
- In my opinion, the thesis of this composition is _____. If this is your thesis, how can you strengthen your rhetorical arguments to better support it? If you intended to have a different thesis, how can you restate your claims to clarify the composition's purpose?
- The project uses sufficient evidence to support your claim that _____. How can you better support the claim that _____?

Questions about Audience and Culture

- What audience are you trying to reach? What are the characteristics of this audience?
- What do you want your audience's reaction to this composition to be?
- How have you accounted for the similarities and differences between you and your audience?
- Are the elements of the composition accessible and meaningful to the audience?

Questions about Genre and Media

- The genre of this text is _____, including conventions common to this genre such as _____. Optional: You might consider including other conventions such as _____ in order to strengthen the content by _____. How does this genre best capture the message you want to convey?
- The media chosen within the project's genre (do/do not) effectively communicate the author's intent by _____. How could using other media such as _____ increase the impact of the communication?
- A transition that works well in this composition is _____. How can you create a more effective transition here: _____?

Revising: Responding to Questions

You will next revise your project, using your discretion to incorporate your peer reviewer's feedback. After considering reviewer comments, actively engage with that feedback to plan your revisions. As with textual compositions, revisions to multimodal compositions often involve rewording, shifting ideas, and rewriting to better address your audience and purpose.



FIGURE 18.22 As you consider revisions, keep in mind your audience and purpose. In this brochure, notice how the author creates a balance between textual information and visual elements such as color, size, and space. (credit: "Brochure Design" by Evan Courtney/flickr, CC BY 2.0)

Answering Questions

To begin the revision process, answer the questions your peer reviewer has posed. Focus first on the rhetorical situation, including your composition's topic, purpose, and audience as well as questions surrounding culture. Reflect on improvements you might make to represent and communicate the rhetorical situation within the scope of a multimodal composition. Consider using these sentence frames to answer your reviewer's questions.

- The reason I chose this genre is _____ (relate to purpose/audience/organization). I could better communicate by _____.
- I used rhetorical appeal through _____. This is effective in this way: _____ but can be strengthened further by _____.
- I considered the culture of (myself/viewers or readers/subject of composition) by _____. Other cultural components I would like to consider or address are _____. My plan to do that is _____.

Next, answer questions about genre and media. *How might the tools available serve you more effectively? Is your choice of media the most effective to communicate with your audience? What aspects of the primary genre are key to helping you convey your issue? How can you introduce other genres, or aspects of other genres, to strengthen the impact?* In responding, be mindful of creating smooth transitions and content that is uncluttered and clear in meaning. Consider using these sentence frames to answer your reviewer's questions.

- The genre _____ captures the message I am trying to convey by _____. I could strengthen this communication by _____.
- Using new media such as _____ or _____ could increase the impact of the communication by _____.
- My plan for _____ (media/mode) and _____ (media/mode) to work together is _____. I will revise my composition to achieve that by _____.
- I will strengthen my transitions by _____.

The student composer of the prototype above might answer a reviewer's questions in the following way:

> I chose the photo essay genre to show the effects of war in Syria in an expressive, meaningful way. I designed a simple layout contrasting the colors black and white to organize the narrative. I primarily called on pathos to invoke the emotions and values of viewers, drawing them in with powerful images, but I think I could strengthen the emotional appeal by rearranging the pictures and more clearly addressing the most powerful statement: that 80 percent of the city was left uninhabitable. I also think my headline could be more attention grabbing, and I plan to revise it to draw viewers in and more accurately reflect the subject matter. I will revise my composition to achieve a more effective presentation by editing my text to make it more direct and by reordering my photos to leave viewers with a more forceful statement.

Revising

In creating multimodal compositions, revising can refer to taking multiple pieces of content and arranging, rearranging, deleting, and adding to the greater whole. Consider the project on the war in Syria. If choosing to create a video of the photo essay with a voice-over, the student might rearrange the order of photographs or choose which photos to show during particular audio clips, depending on the student's reflection on the peer reviewer's questions.

Alternatively, the student might choose to keep the same format, thinking that it best expresses what they hope to communicate. However, the student might make revisions based on the peer reviewer's feedback and their own reflection, in which the student mentions revising the text, reordering photos, and changing the headline. Consider this revision of the sample photo essay, in Figure 18.23.

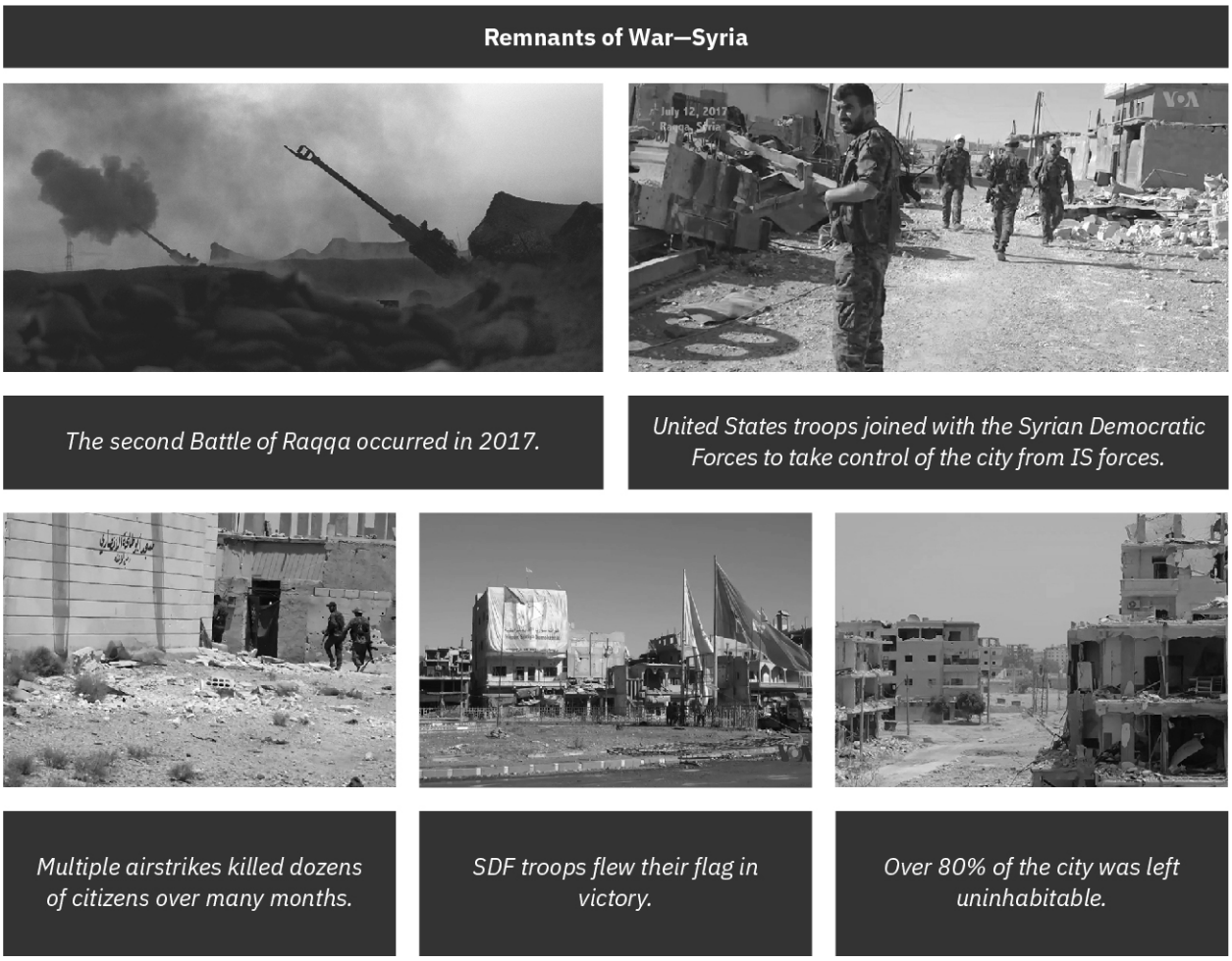


FIGURE 18.23 Sample revision (credit: "SDF fighters in Raqqa downtown" by (top left) United States Marine Corps/ Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain, (top right), (bottom left) & (bottom right) Mahmoud Bali/Wikimedia Commons,

Public Domain; (bottom center) Voice of America Kurdish/Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain)

The author makes revisions according to peer reviewer feedback and reflection of that feedback, particularly as it relates to purpose, organization, and audience. To get a better sense of the revision process, carefully examine the student's thought process.

> I revised the headline from "The Syrian War" to "Remnants of War—Syria." This headline is more engaging for readers and viewers and better reflects the purpose of my project: to convey the desperate situation in Syria resulting from the war that has ravaged citizens' lives.

> I changed the aesthetic by using a black-and-white filter on the photos. Not only does this contrast with the white space and white text, creating a more organized and cleaner look, it more effectively appeals to readers' emotions by emphasizing the destitution left by the Syrian War.

> I rewrote the captions of the final three pictures to make them closer to one another in word count, which is visually more pleasing. But even more important, they create a more powerful narrative, building upon one another.

> I reordered the final two pictures, ending on what I consider the most powerful image and most powerful statement: that 80 percent of the city was uninhabitable after the war. I intend to increase viewers' emotional responses with these changes.

Remember that you do not have to accept every suggestion a peer reviewer makes, but do give each question and suggestion careful thought. Pay close attention to your reviewer's questions and their perception of your purpose and audience in particular, ensuring that they match yours. And again, don't be afraid to experiment. One benefit of multimodal composition, particularly when created with digital media, is that it is relatively quick and easy to manipulate. One valuable tip is to duplicate your work in different workspaces as you make changes, thus saving the major elements of your project should something go wrong.

18.6 Evaluation: Transitions

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Implement conventions from a variety of modes and media to address a range of audiences.
- Match the capacities of different genres to various rhetorical situations.

Ask a peer to use the rubric below to read through your draft. Pay special attention to **transitions** in your composition. Remember that although transitions in various genres may differ, logical transitions are an important element in helping your audience "read" your text.

Linguistic text uses transitions to create relationships between sentences, between paragraphs, and between sections of text. Consider this sentence-to-sentence transition from "Celebrating a Win-Win: 30 Years of Progress under the Pollution Prevention Act" by Alexandra Dapolito Dunn.

> The act gave the agency new tools to join with states, tribes, and communities to prevent pollution *before* it happens. **It also** marked a shift in the paradigm of environmental protection, which had been mostly focused on end-of-pipe pollution control and clean-up strategies.

The phrase *it also* helps readers connect the ideas from each sentence: that the Prevention Pollution Act provides new tools *and* that it focuses on preventing pollution instead of the former strategy of addressing pollution after it occurs. The next sentence from the article begins a new paragraph.

> **Equally important**, the P2 Act strengthened EPA's role as an ally of American businesses, helping them save billions of dollars and improve operations.

Here, the author uses the transition phrase *equally important*, signaling a new idea related to the Prevention Pollution Act (that it saved American businesses money) and providing context for how it ranks in importance

(it is equally important). You can refer to Editing Focus: Paragraphs and Transitions for more information on textual transitions.

In multimodal compositions, you will have to think about transitions differently. First, consider how images and blank space work together when modes are mixed. Often, a margin of space around images helps organize a composition. Colors and other visual features can also serve as transitions, as seen in the following graphic. An important part of multimodal compositions is readability, particularly related to density of text. How might you revise this graphic to increase readability?



FIGURE 18.24 United Nation poster (credit: "UNSR FOAA natural resources poster 2015 A1 (A/HRC/29/25)" by Maina Kiai/flickr, CC BY 2.0)

Further, a composer must make decisions about how different media interact with one another when more than one genre is introduced. Think about multimodal compositions you encounter in your everyday life, such as websites or flyers. Those that are effective may have a host of different features, modes, and media, but they likely have elements in common: they are visually appealing, organized, and provide the information you need without overwhelming. Consider Figure 18.25, a photo essay located at the F-35 Joint Strike Fighter plant in Fort Worth, Texas.



FIGURE 18.25 (credit: "Defense.gov photo" by Cherie Cullen/Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain)

The composer uses different modes to communicate clearly and help readers transition between ideas. While photographs of varying sizes are the primary media used to emphasize the evolution of aircraft design, the composer includes text boxes that overlay photographs and aid in providing context and transition between ideas. In addition, some of the photographs have been cut out and placed so as to rise above the flat surface of the background. In this case, the composer has chosen not to employ white space but to layer the text boxes and photographs on top of a large background photograph. Also missing are long textual blocks. The composer presents the necessary information in short excerpts and quotations.

Rubric

As you know, *how* you present content within your compositions is as important as what content you choose to include. Moving smoothly among elements, genres, and incorporations of various media has a powerful impact on how your audience experiences your composition. Refer to the following rubric throughout the process to help you evaluate your transitions and other conventions.

Score	Critical Language Awareness	Clarity and Coherence	Rhetorical Choices
5 Skillful	The composition effectively communicates a position through a variety of genres, introducing media successfully. The composition also shows ample evidence of the composer's intent to meet or challenge conventional expectations in rhetorically effective ways.	The composer's position or claim is stated clearly, well supported, and directly related to the advocacy issue. The composer's ideas and the media chosen are always clearly presented. Concepts are consistently linked with linguistic, visual, or multimedia transitions that effectively connect ideas.	The project makes clear, substantive, and focused claims advocating for an issue. The composition effectively demonstrates the composer's understanding of purpose, organization, audience, and culture.
4 Accomplished	The composition communicates a position adequately through a variety of genres, introducing media moderately successfully. The composition also shows some evidence of the composer's intent to meet or challenge conventional expectations in rhetorically effective ways.	The composer's position or claim is stated and adequately supported. The ideas and media chosen are connected. Most concepts are linked with linguistic, visual, or multimedia transitions that connect ideas well.	The project makes mostly clear, substantive, and focused claim advocating for an issue. The composition usually demonstrates the composer's understanding of purpose, organization, audience, and culture.
3 Capable	The composition's communication is sometimes unclear. Introduction of genres and media may be unfocused and ineffectual occasionally. The composition also shows limited evidence of the composer's intent to meet or challenge conventional expectations in rhetorically effective ways.	The composer's position or claim is stated and reasonably well supported but may show lapses of convincing support at times. The ideas and media used are not always clearly connected. Some concepts are linked with linguistic, visual, or multimedia transitions, but the transitions may not smooth or appropriate.	The project makes claims that are sometimes unclear, lacking substance, or unfocused while advocating for an issue. The composition is missing some elements that demonstrate the composer's understanding of purpose, organization, audience, and culture.

TABLE 18.3

Score	Critical Language Awareness	Clarity and Coherence	Rhetorical Choices
2 Developing	The composition's communication is often unclear. Introduction of genres and media is more unfocused than focused. The composition also shows emerging evidence of the composer's intent to meet or challenge conventional expectations in rhetorically effective ways. The text also shows limited evidence of the writer's intent to meet or challenge conventional expectations in rhetorically effective ways.	The composer's position or claim is weakly supported. Evidence is either insufficient or irrelevant. The ideas and media used are not effective for the purpose. If linguistic, visual, or multimedia transitions are present, they are usually ineffective or unrelated.	The project makes claims that are unclear and shows little substance or focus. The composition does not demonstrate the composer's understanding of purpose, organization, audience, and culture.
1 Beginning	The composition does not communicate a position and the use of genres and media is ineffective. The composition shows little to no evidence of the composer's intent to meet or challenge conventional expectations in rhetorically effective ways.	The composer's position or claim is not supported. The ideas and media used are disconnected. The composition is missing linguistic, visual, or multimedia transitions, or those used are incorrect, ineffective, or insufficient.	The project's claims are extremely weak. The composition has no discernible purpose, organization, audience, and culture.
Comments:			

TABLE 18.3

18.7 Spotlight on . . . Technology

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Implement a variety of technologies while matching them to environments used to address rhetorical situations.
- Match the capacities of different modes and media to various rhetorical situations.

Technology is a crucial element in multimodal composition. In fact, the emergence of digital technology has vastly changed the landscape of multimodal composition in recent years. The rise of technology has resulted in new communication and composition practices in people's social, academic, and professional lives. Technology also plays a role in the rhetorical approach to writing and composition, increasing the complexity of expression, communication, and persuasion. Indeed, technology has both challenged and transformed long-held ideas about what it means to write.

Within the genre of multimodal composition, there is a growing call for design advocacy, part of which means redefining and recontextualizing the rhetoric of design to make multimodal compositions more inclusive not only for those with differing abilities but also for those marginalized according to social, technological, and cultural equity.

Digital Deserts

One challenge posed by the incorporation of technology in multimodal composition is the presence of **digital**

deserts, or places affected by a digital divide, where residents have no access to the high-speed internet connections required to consume and create digital media. The Federal Communications Commission produced data indicating that in 2017, 21.3 million Americans lacked access to high-speed internet service, and of those people, 2.2 million households had no internet access at all. Studies show that this data may be understated, with even more people living in digital deserts. Rural parts of the country are disproportionately affected, but people living in low-income urban areas make up a significant portion of these numbers.

To participate in the consumption or creation of most multimodal composition, students need access to high-speed internet, defined by the FCC as a download speed of 25 Mbps and an upload speed of 3 Mbps. When no such access exists, cultural, social, and educational disparities arise within the genre of multimodal literature. Students who have less access to the technology required to read, view, or create multimodal works are excluded from this relatively new form of literature, leading to cultural underrepresentation and placing them at academic and social disadvantages.

Enhancing Usability and Accessibility

Other considerations affecting multimodal compositions are usability and accessibility for readers of differing abilities. These may be associated with speech, hearing, vision, and/or motor impairments, among others. Universal accessibility aims to produce content that all people, regardless of abilities, can use, often with assistive technologies, solutions, and tools. Although new fields within the education landscape, such as universal design, have made great strides in usability and accessibility, multimodal content can enhance these strides in unique ways for students and for all consumers of multimodal compositions.

Multimodal compositions often include interaction constraints. These can be thought of as filters that limit a user's ability to access consumer content effectively. For example, a person who has vision impairment may experience interaction constraints when attempting to consume a photo essay. This constraint can be eased through technologies that help make the media more meaningful, such as text and audio alternatives that help the user experience the composition in a way similar to its original form.

Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) are intended to make web content more accessible to people with disabilities. However, creators of multimodal compositions can adapt and apply WCAG rules and principles, such as those discussed below, even to compositions that are not web based.

Provide Informative Titles and Headings

Content titles and headlines that accurately describe and distinguish the composition from others are helpful for contextualizing the composition. A headline usually refers to a composition within something larger, such as an article in a magazine, whereas a title encompasses an entire entity in itself, such as a novel or story that stands on its own. Consider the headline of the blog post you read earlier, "Celebrating a Win-Win: 30 Years of Progress under the Pollution Prevention Act." This headline is informative, telling the audience that the post is about the progress of the Pollution Prevention Act. It also informs readers of the author's perspective on this topic, clearly indicating her belief in the success of the act. For the photo essay about the war in Syria, the student writer revised the original headline to the more specific and meaningful *Remnants of War—Syria*.

Use Headings and Subheads to Convey Meaning and Structure

Headings and short subheads group related information, clearly describe sections of text or media, and provide an outline of the content. Although they are a standard feature of informational texts, headings and subheads can be explored within multimodal compositions as organizational and accessibility features, as they are used in the poster shown in Figure 18.24, *United Nations poster*. The subheads clarify the structure of the composition, indicating features such as the introduction and author's objectives, and provide transitions between sections.

Make Link Text Meaningful

When using hyperlinks within a multimodal composition, write text that describes the content of the link

target. Instead of using vague text such as "click here" or simply using the URL as the hyperlink, use the opportunity to include relevant information about the content of the link. This added content serves as a transition and emphasizes the relationship between the media. Alexandra Dapolito Dunn does this in the blog post in Annotated Sample Reading, specifying in her text the content of the link used:

> President Trump acknowledged the effectiveness of these and other EPA programs in a 2018 Executive Order that directed federal agencies to use EPA's P2 resources to meet their statutory sustainable purchasing requirements.

Write Meaningful Text Alternatives for Graphics

All images and other graphic representations should have meaningful alternative text that helps readers understand the information portrayed in the image and its significance to the function of the composition. Consider Figure 18.26:



FIGURE 18.26 Masses waving flags excitedly cheer for their national soccer teams. (credit: "Long Street party, Final Draw, FIFA 2010 World Cup Cape Town, South Africa "by flowcomm/flickr, CC BY 2.0)

Briefly, the caption provides context and any other important information that cannot be gathered simply by looking at the image. Alternative (Alt) text, in contrast, describes *only* the information that can be gathered by simply looking at the image (the "what the image shows" part of the caption sentence). Alt text for this image might read "Large crowd of soccer fans waves national flags." Alternative text is imperative for those who have vision impairments because it enables them fuller comprehension of the media.

Create Transcripts and Captions for Media

Audiovisual content, such as videos and podcasts, can be especially challenging for users with visual or auditory disabilities. Therefore, include clear and specific transcripts and captions to guide users through content in your multimodal compositions. In video transcripts, describe visual content (for example, "Joey enters the room" whenever that action occurs). For audio content, include text that indicates spoken information and other sound that is important for understanding the content (for example, "Trumpets softly

play the national anthem in the background"). Again, these small additions make your multimodal media accessible to consumers of all abilities.



FIGURE 18.27 Closed captions and other forms of accessible text help those with different abilities consume multimodal text. The captioning in this image indicates that one figure offers help and the other figure shows appreciation. (credit: "Closed-Caption-Example" by Palmtree3000/Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain)

Publishing Your Work

One of the most exciting parts of composing is publishing your work. Technology affords multimodal composers numerous options for publishing. Whether or not you create your composition through digital means, you can use technology in the publishing process. First, know that you want your published product to be a finished work that incorporates the revisions and edits you made during the peer review process. This step is occasionally skipped in the multimodal composition process, mostly because digital publishing can be more accessible than other traditional publishing methods. Nevertheless, as a composer, you want your published product to be your best work.

Depending on which modes and media you include, consider the following options for publishing your multimodal advocacy project.

- Blogs, which usually include text, images, and videos, can be self-published on free or inexpensive web-based platforms such as WordPress, Adobe Experience Manager, and others. Any author or group can start a blog and create posts that incorporate multimodal content.
- As an alternative to blogs, consider the digital **flipbook** format, the equivalent of a digital magazine. Platforms such as Issuu allow content creators to organize content in a format in which the viewer scrolls left and right by "flipping" pages. Flipbooks offer more options for layout, organization, and transitions.
- You may instead choose to publish your completed composition on a **video** hosting site such as YouTube or Vimeo.
- You can also use technology to publish non-digital multimodal compositions, such as performances, presentations, or hard-copy posters and the like. This kind of publication typically involves another layer of mode mixing, such as recording a live performance or uploading a picture of an artwork to a digital platform.

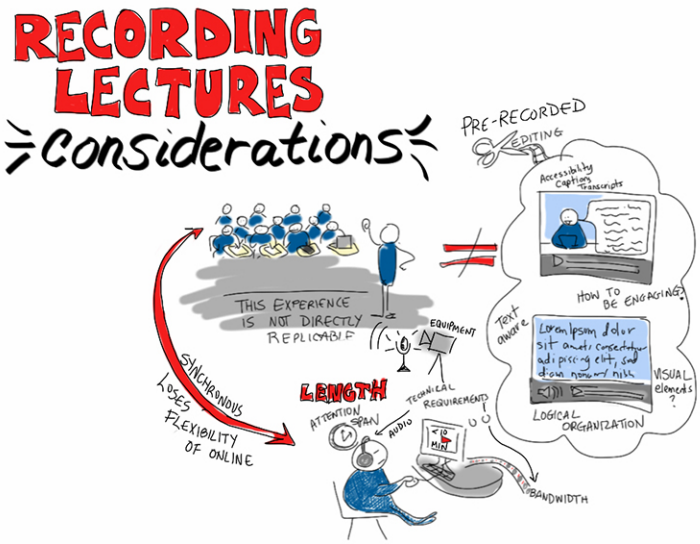


FIGURE 18.28 Publishing a multimedia composition will allow you to present your best work to spread your message. (credit: "Recording Lectures ... Considerations" by Giulia Forsythe/Wikimedia Commons, CC0)

No matter what technology you choose, you will want to follow an organized writing process and ensure that your choices honor your purpose, your audience, and the organization you have chosen for your work. Thinking specifically about your advocacy project, consider what you want to accomplish and to whom you are speaking. *What digital publishing options can accomplish your goals? How does your intended audience consume digital media?* Choosing your publication method is as important as choosing the modes and media.

18.8 Portfolio: Multimodalism

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Write about the development of multimodal composition.
- Compose a reflection on how the processes affect your work.

After creating your multimodal advocacy project, think critically about the development process, including how you chose genres, modes, and specific media to include; your process for creating transitions; and ways in which you incorporated usability and accessibility into your finished project.

Reflective Writing: Letter to Your Instructor

As you reflect on your multimodal composition and the process you used to create it, answer these questions, supporting your answers with evidence from your project. Then compose a letter to your instructor that incorporates your answers and addresses any other parts of the composition process that come to mind.

- How would you articulate your role as a composer? (Hint: Who are you as the author—what is your identity in this role? To whom are you speaking, and for what purpose?)
- Why did you choose the advocacy topic that you did? Do you have a personal connection?
- On which parts of the composition process (planning, research, drafting, revising) did you spend the most time? Why did these parts occupy you the longest? What, if anything, would you change if you could do it again?
- How did considering your audience change your development process? What opportunities did you have to think critically about social and cultural issues?
- Why did you choose the rhetorical devices that you did? What factors helped you decide on them? How did the situation influence your rhetorical appeals?
- What factors helped you determine the primary genre, mode(s), and media you chose? Did you change

those elements at any point in the composition process? If so, why?
- How did peer review and revision help clarify your ideas, organization, or composition?
- How did you show relationships between the ideas and media? What changes did you make to improve your transitions?
- What did you learn about your topic and the composition process through the revision process?
- How did you address considerations for usability and accessibility, using technology or otherwise?
- Which parts of the composition came more easily than others?
- How did thinking about publishing affect your final product?

Further Reading

These titles are examples of multimodal compositions that will help you view and analyze the variety of possibilities present in the multimodal genres.

The following is an example of the podcast genre, which uses the aural mode. However, the accompanying website incorporates multiple supporting modes, with images, hyperlinks, and other information that bring in other genres to increase understanding.

Ridgen, David, host. "The Family." *Someone Knows Something*, season 1, episode 1, CBC, 26 Feb. 2016.

The following is an example of the photo essay genre, though the author has turned his photo essay into a video, incorporating a different supporting mode.

Kalina, Noah. *Noah Takes a Photo of Himself Every Day for 20 Years*. *YouTube*, uploaded by Noah Kalina, 13 Jan. 2020.

The following is an example of a public service announcement, delivered as a video. Note the use of multiple modes and the rhetorical devices present in convincing viewers to pursue careers in STEM (science, technology, engineering, and math).

Wishes. CA Technologies, 6 Jan. 2017.

The following is an example similar to the photo essay genre, although it incorporates elements of a blog with a text introduction.

The Picture Show: Photo Stories from NPR. NPR, 2021.

The following is an example of the documentary genre, a primarily visual genre that uses various rhetorical devices to persuade the audience.

Food, Inc. Directed by Robert Kenner, Magnolia Pictures / Participant / River Road Entertainment, 2008.

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